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ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

ENG 101: Nigerian Literature in English - Texts, Contexts and Close Reading

A reading method for the novels, plays and poems on your first-year list

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
English Language & Literature | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

First-year literature is not about memorising plots; it is about making defensible claims from evidence. This pack covers the historical shaping of Nigerian literature in English, the shift from cultural nationalism to critique of the nation, and a close-reading method you can apply to any text on the list.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Place a text in the phases of Nigerian literary history.
- Distinguish close reading from plot summary.
- Analyse narrative voice, imagery and structure.
- Build an argument supported by quotation.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

A short map of the field

Know the phases well enough to date and situate a text.

- Cultural nationalism and the generation that wrote back to colonial representation.
- Independence-era optimism and its rapid disillusionment.
- Civil war literature and the literature of trauma.
- Postcolonial critique of the nation-state, elite politics and corruption.
- Diaspora writing and the global circulation of Nigerian fiction.
- Contemporary writing on gender, sexuality, migration and technology.

Close reading, step by step

The method is repeatable and it earns marks.

1. Choose a short passage that clearly matters to the text.
2. Note its literal content in one sentence.
3. Analyse diction: which words are unexpected and why?
4. Analyse imagery and figurative language.
5. Analyse syntax and rhythm: short clauses or long accumulations?
6. Connect the passage to a pattern in the whole text and to your argument.

> **Quote precisely**
> A short quotation, correctly embedded and analysed, beats a long block quotation that is never discussed.

Context without overreach

Biography explains less than you think.

- Use history to explain textual choices, not to replace analysis.
- Avoid reading a character as the author's autobiography.
- Note publication date and reception when they matter.
- Treat oral tradition as form and influence, not as background colour.
- Read the introduction and notes, then form your own reading.
- Cite editions consistently.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What is the difference between close reading and summary?

Answer: Summary reports events; close reading analyses how language makes meaning and supports an argument.

2. Name two phases of Nigerian literary history.

Answer: Cultural nationalism and independence-era disillusionment; civil-war writing and diaspora writing are further phases.

3. Why is biography an unreliable explanation on its own?

Answer: It reduces textual choices to authorial experience and ignores form, audience and literary tradition.

4. What should you do after quoting a line?

Answer: Analyse its diction, imagery or syntax and explain how it supports your claim.

5. Why does edition matter?

Answer: Pagination and textual variants differ between editions, so citations must name the edition used.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Build a timeline of four phases with one text each.
- [ ] Close-read one passage in 300 words.
- [ ] Annotate quotations in your set text.
- [ ] Write one argued paragraph with claim, evidence and analysis.
- [ ] Read one critical essay and summarise its argument.
- [ ] Check your citations against a single edition.
- [ ] Exchange essays and test each other's evidence.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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